us; for he was our friend when cardinal, and now he will be our enemy as Pope." His prediction very shortly came true.[15]

Innocent IV had a lawyer's mindset, and before long was combining Roman law with canon principles to come up with a clear articulation of his own power. Church law, he wrote, was above secular law; and since, in Roman jurisprudence, the prince stands above the law, so the pope also stands above church law, unbound by it, able to change it, depart from it, or even nullify it as needed. *Absolute papal monarchy*: it was a theory that Innocent IV spent much of his papacy elaborating and defending, and it was almost custom-designed to infuriate the emperor.[16]

Innocent IV began his papacy by ordering Frederick to give up all of the territory he had conquered since his excommunication by Gregory IX, five years earlier. When Frederick refused, Innocent IV traveled to the French city of Lyons—outside of Italy, and outside of the emperor's grasp. There he renewed both the excommunication and the call for Frederick's deposition as emperor.[17]

This began yet another war of letters, with both pope and emperor pleading their case to the rest of the world. "I hold my crown from God alone; neither the Pope, the Council, nor the devil shall rend it from me!" Frederick raged. "What might not all kings fear from the presumption of a such a pope?" "When a sick man who cannot be helped by mild remedies undergoes a surgical incision or cautery," wrote Innocent IV, primly, in response, "he rages in bitterness of spirit against his doctor. . . . If then Frederick, formerly emperor, strives to accuse . . . the sacred judge of the universal church . . . he is behaving in the same fashion."[18]

Inevitably, the war of words devolved into simple war. Innocent IV declared one of Frederick's German subjects, Henry Raspe, to be the new king of Germany in place of young Conrad (now seventeen); Henry marched on Conrad's own forces but died on campaign, so Innocent threw his weight behind another candidate, William of Holland. While Conrad fought in Germany, Frederick II started to lose his foothold in Italy. Bishops and cardinals loyal to the pope were preaching revolt to the emperor's subjects in Sicily and Lombardy. In early February of 1248, Frederick's army was unexpectedly defeated while laying siege to the city of Parma; the emperor was forced to flee to Cremona, and most of the gold and treasure he had been using to finance the war fell into Lombard hands. The Milanese, heading the Lombard League, led the recapture of Modena; Como fell; and in 1250, still battling, Frederick II grew ill with dysentery, the scourge of a soldier's existence.[19]